Lesson 4 Day of the Dead: A Joyous Celebration of Death

CEFR B2 Worksheet

Name: _____ Class: _____

Vocabulary & Phrases

Words for Production

1. joyous

adj. 令人愉快的 making one feel very happy; filling one with happiness

2. accompany

vt. 陪伴 to go somewhere with someone

↳ **company** n. [U] 陪伴

3. essential

adj. 本質的；基本的 related to the basic nature or most important part

adj. 必要的；極其重要的 necessary

4. concept

n. [C] 概念 an idea one can imagine or think up

5. mourn

vt. vi. 哀悼 to feel very sad about one's death and/or act in a way that shows this sadness

↳ **mournful** adj. 悲慟的

6. sorrow

n. [U] 悲傷 great sadness or unhappiness

↳ **sorrowful** adj. 悲傷的

7. occasion

n. [C] 場合 a special or significant event or happening

↳ **occasional** adj. 偶爾的

8. reunion

n. [C] 重逢；團聚 a special occasion for a family, class, etc. to get together after being apart for a while

↳ **reunite** vt. usually passive 重逢；重聚

9. anticipate

vt. 期盼 to look forward to something

↳ **anticipation** n. [U] 預料

10. arrival

n. [U] 到達；到來 the act of one's coming to or reaching a certain place

11. decorate

vt. 裝飾 to make something look more attractive by putting things on it

↳ **decoration** n. [C] 裝飾（品）

12. preference

n. sing. 偏愛 a stronger liking of something compared to another or others

↳ **prefer** vt. 偏愛

13. reception

n. sing. 歡迎；接待 a way in which someone or something is received, welcomed, or accepted

↳ **receptionist** n. [C] 接待員

14. feast

vi. 盡情享用 to eat and drink a lot with great pleasure, often to celebrate a special occasion

n. [C] 宴會 a large meal, often to celebrate a special occasion

15. dawn

n. [U] 黎明；破曉 the beginning of the day, when sunlight first appears

16. transform

vt. 使改變形態 to change something or someone in nature, shape, or form

↳ **transformation** n. [C] 轉變

17. resemble

vt. 看起來像；像 to look or seem like something or someone else

↳ **resemblance** n. [C] 相似；相像

18. participate

vi. 參加 to take part or be involved in something such as an activity or a sporting event

↳ **participation** n. [U] 參加；參與

19. mock

vt. 嘲弄；不尊重 to make fun of or treat someone or something with very little respect by copying

adj. 虛假的；不誠實的 not genuine; fake

20. recognize

vt. 承認；意識到；體認到 to be aware of and accept as true or real

vt. 認出；辨識出 to know and remember upon seeing

↳ **recognition** n. [U] 承認

21. inevitable

adj. 不可避免的 impossible to avoid; sure to happen

22. cycle

n. [C] 循環 a continuous process in which the steps are always repeated in the same order

23. annual

adj. 每年的 happening or done once per year

24. await

vt. 等待 to wait for; to anticipate

25. escape

vt. 避免 to get away from or avoid

vi. 逃跑；逃走 to get away, as from a dangerous place

↳ **escape** n. [C] 逃跑

Idioms and Phrases

1. scare...to death 把……嚇得要命

to seriously terrify one

2. make one's hair stand on end 使人毛骨悚然

to make one feel extremely scared, horrified, or shocked

3. in honor of 紀念

as a sign of respect for or in appreciation of

4. in advance (of...) 提前；事先；在……之前
beforehand; at an earlier time

5. die out 逐漸消失
to gradually fade or disappear

Words for Recognition

1. deceased *adj.* 已故的
2. Mexican / Mexico *adj. / n.* 墨西哥的 / 墨西哥（人）
3. afterlife *n. sing.* 死後的世界；死後（靈魂）的生活
4. Aztec *n.* 阿茲提克人
5. marigold *n. [C]* 萬壽菊；金盞花
6. skull *n. [C]* 頭骨；顱骨
7. grave *n. [C]* 墳墓；墓穴
8. cemetery *n. [C]* 墓地；公墓
9. altar *n. [C]* 祭壇；聖壇
10. merry *adj.* 快樂的；愉快的
11. graveyard *n. [C]* 墓地；墓場
12. venue *n. [C]* 舉行地點；活動場地
13. skeleton *n. [C]* 骨骼；骨架

Dialogue Practice

Read the dialogue below. Every bold, underlined word is a target vocabulary word used exactly once.

Leo: Hey Maya, have you started the project on the Day of the Dead yet? I watched a short video last night, and it was such a **joyous** celebration — way more colorful than I expected.

Maya: Yeah, I'm still wrapping my head around the whole **concept**. At first it felt strange to picture death as something to celebrate instead of fear.

Leo: Same here. But the book says families actually **anticipate** the spirits' return instead of dreading it — they genuinely look forward to it.

Maya: Right, and it's not just a one-time thing — it's an **annual** tradition, so every household already knows exactly what to prepare each year.

Leo: Exactly. Weeks ahead of time, they **decorate** altars at home with marigolds and candles.

Maya: It reminds me a little of Tomb Sweeping Day here, actually. We have our own **occasion** for honoring ancestors too, even if it looks completely different.

Leo: True. And whole extended families **participate** together on the Day of the Dead — kids, parents, grandparents, everyone shows up.

Maya: My little brother always insists on getting to **accompany** my grandma when she visits our family's grave every spring.

Leo: That's sweet. Some of my cousins used to **mock** the idea of talking out loud to a tombstone, like it was silly, but I don't think that's fair at all.

Maya: No, it's not making fun of anything — it's just a different way to **mourn** and remember someone you loved.

Leo: True. Anyway, back to the video — do you remember how the whole point was to let the dead briefly **escape** the usual gloom people associate with being dead, just for one night?

Maya: Ha, kind of! Families stay at the cemetery lighting candles and talking until **dawn**, almost like their relatives are sitting right there with them.

Maya: Actually, this topic makes me think of my own family. Last month we had a small **reunion** at my grandfather's house — the first time everyone had gathered since he passed away.

Leo: Oh, I didn't know that. I'm sorry — that must have been a time of real **sorrow** for your whole family.

Maya: It was hard at first, but my aunt planned everything so carefully. She even tracked the **arrival** of every relative, including the ones flying in from overseas.

Leo: That's a lot of coordinating for one gathering.

Maya: It was worth it, though. Everyone cooked his favorite dishes — my aunt had asked each person about their food **preference** beforehand so nothing he loved was left out.

Leo: That's such a warm way to honor him.

Maya: It really did feel like a warm **reception** for everyone, even though the reason we were gathering was sad. We ended up telling old stories and literally **feasted** on his favorite noodles until almost midnight.

Leo: Wow, that sounds like it **transformed** what could've been a purely sad day into something closer to a celebration.

Maya: It did, honestly. My cousin even said he's started to **resemble** our grandfather more as he gets older — same laugh, same way of telling jokes.

Leo: I think that's basically the whole point the Day of the Dead is making too — people **recognize** that death is simply part of life instead of pretending it isn't.

Maya: Right. Once you accept that it's an **inevitable** part of the natural **cycle**, it gets a little easier to celebrate someone's life instead of only grieving their death.

Leo: That makes sense. I guess all of us **await** that same moment eventually, so maybe it's healthier to make peace with it early.

Maya: Exactly. And honestly, learning about this festival feels genuinely **essential** for understanding how differently cultures can approach the exact same idea.

Word Bank (in order of appearance): *joyous, concept, anticipate, annual, decorate, occasion, participate, accompany, mock, mourn, escape, dawn, reunion, sorrow, arrival, preference, reception, feast, transform, resemble, recognize, inevitable, cycle, await, essential*

Part A — Comprehension & Inference

1. According to the passage, how do Mexicans treat the spirits of the dead when they return during the Day of the Dead, and what do families do beforehand to prepare for their arrival?

2. What is the significance of November 1 and November 2 in the Day of the Dead celebration?

3. Why do families place each deceased relative's favorite food and drink on the home altar rather than simply offering the same general items for everyone?

4. Why might the author describe the cemetery as being "transformed" from something "horrifying" into "a venue of joy"?

Part B — Extended Response

1. The passage ends with the line "If we cannot escape death, why not celebrate it?" Do you agree or disagree with this attitude toward death? Write a ~100-word response explaining your view.

2. The Day of the Dead turns potentially frightening images — skeletons, skulls, graveyards — into cheerful, cartoon-like decorations and costumes. Write a ~100-word response discussing what effect this kind of transformation might have on how people process difficult emotions like fear or grief.



Part C — Grammar Pattern Practice

Pattern 1: Sentence Pattern — S + be + thought/said/believed + to VR / have + p.p.....

Example: Many people think that daily meditation reduces stress. → Daily meditation is thought to reduce stress.

1. People say that the new "study-with-me" livestreams help students concentrate by creating a sense of quiet company. Complete the sentence using the pattern: "The new study-with-me trend _____."

2. Everyone on campus believes that the school already changed its attendance policy before the semester began. Complete the sentence using the pattern: "The school's attendance policy _____."

Pattern 2: Language in Use — would rather...than... / would...rather than...

Example: On weekends, Amy prefers reading alone to going to crowded parties. → Amy would rather read alone than go to crowded parties.

3. You finally have a completely free Saturday after exams. Using the pattern, write a sentence about what you would rather do with your free time instead of catching up on schoolwork.

4. Your favorite band is performing the night before a big exam. Using the pattern, write a sentence expressing your honest preference between going to the concert and staying home to prepare.

Part D — Chinese to English Translation

1. (Pattern 1: Sentence Pattern)

科學家普遍相信，近年來極端氣候事件的增加與全球暖化有關。

(believe; extreme weather events)

2. (Pattern 2: Language in Use)

與其花整個週末滑手機，我寧願把時間花在志工服務上，幫助真正需要幫助的人。

(would rather; volunteer work)

Part E-1 綜合測驗 (Integrated Cloze Test)

Every summer, families across Japan take part in Obon, a centuries-old festival ___(1)___ honoring the spirits of deceased ancestors. ___(2)___ the exact dates vary by region, most areas celebrate Obon in mid-August. According to tradition, the souls of the dead return home during this period to visit their living relatives. To help guide these spirits, families hang lanterns outside their homes and ___(3)___ family graves to clean them and leave offerings of food. ___(4)___ many younger Japanese people now live far from their hometowns, Obon has become one of the busiest travel seasons of the year, as millions return home to reunite with family. On the final night, many communities hold a lantern-floating ceremony, in which paper lanterns are set adrift on rivers or the sea to ___(5)___ the spirits back to the afterlife. In some regions, people also perform the Bon Odori, a traditional dance ___(6)___ to have developed hundreds of years ago as a way to welcome and entertain the returning spirits. ___(7)___ the holiday is deeply connected to death, its mood is anything but somber — children run through festival grounds carrying sparklers, food stalls fill the streets with the smell of grilled snacks, and drums echo late into the night. In fact, many companies even give employees several days off specifically so that ___(8)___. Many families say they ___(9)___ spend this one week honoring their ancestors properly than simply treat it like any other summer holiday. As other seasonal customs fade from modern life, Obon shows no sign that it will ___(10)___ anytime soon, remaining one of Japan's most cherished cultural events.

( ) 1.
(A) referred to
(B) dedicated to
(C) attached to
(D) limited to

( ) 2.
(A) Because
(B) Unless
(C) So that
(D) Although

( ) 3.
(A) visit
(B) attend
(C) assist
(D) inspect

( ) 4.
(A) Although
(B) Unless
(C) Because
(D) While

( ) 5.
(A) trap
(B) block
(C) warn
(D) guide

( ) 6.
(A) saying
(B) said
(C) to say
(D) says

( ) 7.

(A) Because
(B) Unless
(C) While
(D) Since

( ) 8.

(A) employees can travel home and reunite with their families
(B) workers can save money by not traveling anywhere
(C) businesses can reduce their operating costs during the holiday
(D) they can stay home and avoid the summer heat

( ) 9.

(A) would like
(B) would rather
(C) would prefer
(D) would better

( ) 10.

(A) die off
(B) fade in
(C) burn out
(D) die out

Part E-2 文意選填 (Vocabulary Cloze)

(A) annual	(B) anticipate	(C) dawn	(D) decorated	(E) essential
(F) feast	(G) in honor of	(H) joyous	(I) preference	(J) reunion

Imagine a deceased loved one returning to join your family for a holiday. For Mexicans, this is far from frightening — it is the ___(1)___ idea behind the Day of the Dead, a festival that treats death with humor instead of sorrow. On this ___(2)___ occasion, family members gather for a joyful ___(3)___, ___(4)___ those who have moved on to the afterlife. Rather than fearing the returning spirits, families ___(5)___ their arrival, buying marigolds, candles, and ___(6)___ sugar skulls ahead of time. At home, they set up an altar with photos and each relative's favorite food, chosen according to personal ___(7)___. Later, they visit the cemetery, where they light candles and ___(8)___ with the souls until ___(9)___, turning a once-frightening graveyard into a venue of joy. Today, this ___(10)___ celebration, held every November 1 and 2, remains one of Mexico's most cherished traditions.

1. ___ 2. ___ 3. ___ 4. ___ 5. ___

6. ___ 7. ___ 8. ___ 9. ___ 10. ___

Part E-3 篇章結構 (Discourse Structure)

Throughout the Day of the Dead, colorful, cartoon-like images of the dead appear everywhere, from cookies shaped like skulls to flags strung with paper skeletons. ___(41)___ To an outsider watching these cheerful scenes for the first time, it might look as though Mexicans are simply making fun of death. ___(42)___ In reality, nothing could be further from the truth. ___(43)___ Instead of looking away from mortality, the festival invites people to look death in the eye and accept it as a natural part of every life. ___(44)___ Every parade, costume, and candlelit grave, then, becomes a quiet lesson passed from one generation to the next. ___(45)___

(A) Children who grow up surrounded by these cheerful images learn early that death is nothing to hide from or feel ashamed to discuss.

(B) Many children and adults alike dress up in skeleton costumes and paint their faces to resemble skulls before joining lively street parades.

(C) After all, laughing at a decorated skull or dancing through the streets dressed as a skeleton seems, at first glance, disrespectful.

(D) As a result, fewer young Mexicans are choosing to participate in the festival each year, worried that it no longer fits modern life.

(E) The costumes and playful imagery are not meant to disrespect the dead; they are a way of embracing death rather than fearing it.

(F) Hopefully, as long as this message continues to be shared each November, the tradition will never die out.

41. ___ 42. ___ 43. ___ 44. ___ 45. ___

Part E-4 閱讀混合題 (Mixed Reading Comprehension)

Text 1 — The Home Altar (Ofrenda)

Before the Day of the Dead arrives, Mexican families prepare carefully. They purchase marigolds, candles, and decorated sugar skulls bearing the names of their departed relatives, along with special bread made just for the occasion. At home, they set up a colorful altar and place photographs of their deceased loved ones on it, along with beverages and dishes that each family member had a preference for while alive. This warm reception is meant to make the returning spirits feel welcomed and remembered, as if they had never truly left the family at all.

Text 2 — The Cemetery Vigil

Later in the evening, families leave their homes and head to the cemetery — a place normally associated with sorrow. There, they decorate the graves of their loved ones and light one candle for each dead person being honored. Cheerful and merry, they feast with the departed souls and keep each other company until dawn. For one night, the cemetery is transformed from a quiet, frightening place into a lively venue filled with food, laughter, and candlelight, as families stay together until the sun rises the next morning.

Question 1 (Multi-Select)

Based on Text 1 and Text 2, which of the following statements are TRUE? Select ALL that apply.

☐ (A) Families only decorate the altar with items that are the same for every relative, regardless of personal taste.
☐ (B) According to Text 1, families bring food and drink chosen according to each relative's personal preference.
☐ (C) According to Text 2, the cemetery celebration ends shortly after midnight.
☐ (D) According to Text 2, a separate candle is lit for each individual being honored at the grave.
☐ (E) Text 1 states that families visit the cemetery before setting up the altar at home.
☐ (F) According to Text 2, the celebration at the cemetery can continue from night until early morning.

Question 2 (Short Answer)

Find the one word in Text 2 that means "the time when the sun first rises."

Questions 3–4 (Fill in the Blanks)

On the Day of the Dead, families prepare in advance, adding thoughtful ___(49)___ to both the home altar and the family graves to welcome their departed loved ones. Although a cemetery is usually seen as a ___(50)___ place, for one night it becomes filled with warmth, laughter, and candlelight.

49. _____ **50.** _____